



most renowned were Italian noblewomen from the House of Medici, a powerful and wealthy dynasty. The first, Catherine de' Medici, ruled in the place of her young son from 1560 to 1563 and continued to be a major influence on the country for the remainder of her life; and her relative, Marie de' Medici, acted as regent for her son Louis XIV from 1610 to 1617, and ruled France until the "Sun King" came of age.

In contrast, a small number of states practice matrilineal succession, in which titles are inherited through the female line. In the African Ashanti Kingdom, for example, the queen mother is an incredibly important and powerful figure. Today, many monarchies have reformed their succession laws and instituted a system of absolute primogeniture, whereby the monarch's oldest child inherits the throne, regardless of gender. The first to do so was Sweden in 1980; most other European monarchies have since followed, including the UK in 2015.

▲ Habsburg Empress

Maria Theresa, shown here at her coronation, was the Habsburg Empire's only female leader. She ruled for four decades. Although she made her husband co-ruler, she never let him manage state affairs.



PROFILES

INFLUENTIAL RULERS

Ku-Baba (b.c. 24th century BCE) was the only woman listed on the Sumerian King List, a tablet recording those endowed with the divine right of kingship. According to the list, Kubaba was a tavern-keeper before she became queen of the city of Kish (near modern Tell al-Uhaymir, Iraq). The Mesopotamians worshiped her as a goddess.

Empress Theodora (c. 497–548 CE) was the daughter of a bear trainer. She became the mistress of Justinian, heir to the Eastern Roman Empire, and married him in 525. When Justinian ascended in 527, Theodora became his chief adviser and was made empress. She had her own court and seal, and her influence led to divorce law reforms.

Margaret I (1353–1412) was a Danish princess who married the King of Norway when she was ten; they had one son, Olaf. After her father and husband died in 1375 and 1380 respectively, she secured the Danish and Norwegian crowns for her son, and ruled in his name. When Olaf died in 1387, Margaret became regent of Denmark and Norway, and in 1388 became ruler of Sweden, thereby laying the foundation for the later union of the three kingdoms in 1523.

Amina of Zazzau (1533–1610) was queen of the medieval African kingdom of Zazzau, now part of northern Nigeria. A great military tactician, Amina led her people to conquer many surrounding Hausa lands during her 34-year rule and created trade routes for her empire. Amina has been cited as the inspiration for the 1990s television show *Xena: Warrior Princess*.

Maharani Ahilyabai Holkar (1725–1795) married the Maharaja of Malwa (a Hindu kingdom in India) as an eight-year-old. After the deaths of her husband, father-in-law, and son she became ruler of Malwa in 1767. She led armies against invading forces to maintain her state's independence.

Catherine the Great (1729–1796) married the heir to the Russian throne in 1745. Ambitious and clever, she regarded her husband as unfit to rule. When he became emperor in 1762 she led a coup against him and became empress. During her reign, Catherine expanded Russia's territory by over 200,000 square miles (520,000 sq km).